

سُورَةُ
الْبَيِّنَةِ



Sūrat al-Bayyinah

The Clear Proof — an āyah-by-āyah tafsīr

Drawing on Ibn Kathīr · as-Sa'dī · al-Jalālayn · aṭ-Ṭabarī · al-Qurṭubī · al-Baghawī

The Sūrah at a glance

8

āyāt

98

in muṣḥaf order

30

juz' ('Amma)

Madanī

per the majority

Names of the sūrah

- Al-Bayyinah — “the Clear Proof”, from āyah 1
- Lam Yakun — its opening words (Bukhārī’s heading)
- Al-Qayyimah, Al-Bariyyah, Al-Munfakkīn — also listed by al-Qurṭubī

Central theme

Allah sent a Messenger with a clear, upright Book. The proof is now established — and humanity splits into two: the worst of creation and the best of creation, each with its recompense.

Its virtue: the Prophet ﷺ recites it to Ubayy

Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī & Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim — on the authority of Anas ibn Mālik رضى الله عنه

The Prophet ﷺ said to Ubayy ibn Ka'b: **"Allah has commanded me to recite to you: Lam yakuni-lladhīna kafarū..."**

Ubayy asked: "He named me to you?"
He ﷺ said: "Yes."

And Ubayy wept.

Why Ubayy?

He was among the foremost reciters of the Companions — the Prophet ﷺ said: "the best reciter among them is Ubayy."

Lesson (Ibn Kathīr)

Reciting to one more learned than oneself is a sunnah of teaching — and the honour lies in being named by Allah.

The tafsīr sources in this deck



Ibn Kathīr

d. 774 AH

Tafsīr al-Qur'ān al-'Aẓīm — explains Qur'ān by Qur'ān, then Sunnah, then the Companions and Tābi'ūn.



as-Sa'dī

d. 1376 AH

Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān — concise, focused on meanings, guidance and practical lessons.



al-Jalālayn

al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī

Tafsīr al-Jalālayn — a word-by-word gloss; brief and precise in its definitions.



Others

aṭ-Ṭabarī • al-Qurṭubī • al-Baghawī

Used for the range of early opinions, language and fiqh points.

Note: tafsīr points are summarised and paraphrased in English — check against the Arabic originals before teaching.

Three movements in eight āyāt

1-3

The Clear Proof arrives

Disbelievers would not leave their state until the Bayyinah came: a Messenger reciting purified pages with upright writings.

4-5

Division & the one command

They split only after knowledge came — though all were commanded the same: sincere worship, ṣalāh and zakāh.

6-8

Two destinies

Worst of creation in the Fire; best of creation in gardens of 'Adn — Allah pleased with them, they with Him.

Āyah 1 • The Clear Proof



لَمْ يَكُنِ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتَابِ وَالْمُشْرِكِينَ مُنْفَكِّينَ حَتَّى تَأْتِيَهُمُ الْبَيِّنَةُ

Those who disbelieved among the People of the Book and the polytheists were not going to desist until the Clear Proof came to them.

Ibn Kathīr

People of the Book = Jews and Christians; mushrikūn = idol-worshippers, Arab and non-Arab. Munfakkīn, per Mujāhid: they would not end their state until the truth became clear to them. The Bayyinah is then explained in the next āyah.

as-Sa'dī

They would not leave their disbelief and misguidance until the proof came — and when it came, the truth was laid bare and the argument against them was established. No excuse remained.

al-Jalālayn

Munfakkīn: leaving what they were upon. Al-Bayyinah: the clear proof — Muḥammad ﷺ.

Āyah 2–3 · A Messenger and purified pages

2–3

رَسُولٌ مِّنَ اللَّهِ يَتْلُو صُحُفًا مُّطَهَّرَةً ﴿٢﴾ فِيهَا كُتِبَ قِيمَةٌ

A Messenger from Allah, reciting purified pages, in which are upright writings.

Ibn Kathīr

The Messenger ﷺ recites the Qur’ān, recorded in honoured, purified pages on high (cf. ‘Abasa 80:13–16). Kutub qayyimah, per Ibn Jarīr: writings from Allah that are upright, just and straight — free of error.

as-Sa’dī

The pages are purified from any approach of the devils and touched only by the purified. Qayyimah: true in their news and just in their commands — guiding to truth and the straight path.

al-Jalālayn

Muṭahharah: purified of falsehood. Kutub qayyimah: straight, upright rulings (aḥkām mustaqīmah).

Āyah 4 · They divided — after knowledge



وَمَا تَفَرَّقَ الَّذِينَ أُوتُوا الْكِتَابَ إِلَّا مِنْ بَعْدِ مَا جَاءَتْهُمْ الْبَيِّنَةُ

And those who were given the Scripture did not divide until after the Clear Proof had come to them.

Ibn Kathīr

Like Āl ‘Imrān 3:105. He links it to the ḥadīth of the sects: the Jews split into 71, the Christians into 72, and this ummah into 73 — all in the Fire except one: what the Prophet ﷺ and his Companions are upon.

as-Sa‘dī

Their division was not from lack of clarity: it came after the proof, out of envy and transgression. The proof should have united them; their desires split them.

al-Jalālayn

Before it, they agreed they would believe in him when he came. When he came, some believed and some disbelieved out of envy.

Āyah 5 • The one command: the upright religion



وَمَا أُمِرُوا إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُوا اللَّهَ مُخْلِصِينَ لَهُ الدِّينَ حُنَفَاءَ وَيُقِيمُوا الصَّلَاةَ وَيُؤْتُوا الزَّكَاةَ ۚ وَذَلِكَ دِينُ الْقِيَمَةِ

They were commanded only to worship Allah, sincere to Him in religion, inclining to truth; to establish prayer and give zakāh. That is the religion of the upright.

Ibn Kathīr

As in al-Anbiyā' 21:25 and an-Naḥl 16:36. Ḥunafā': turning away from shirk to tawḥīd. Ṣalāh is the best bodily worship; zakāh is excellence to the needy. Imams such as az-Zuhrī and ash-Shāfi'ī took this āyah as proof that deeds are part of īmān.

as-Sa'dī

This is what every revealed law commanded. Ikhlāṣ: seeking only Allah's Face in all worship. Ṣalāh and zakāh are named for their merit — they combine devotion to the Creator with goodness to creation.

al-Jalālayn

Ḥunafā': firmly on the religion of Ibrāhīm and the religion of Muḥammad ﷺ. Dīn al-qayyimah: the religion of the straight community (al-millah al-mustaqīmah).

Āyah 6 • The worst of creation



إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا مِنْ أَهْلِ الْكِتَابِ وَالْمُشْرِكِينَ فِي نَارِ جَهَنَّمَ خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا أُولَئِكَ هُمْ شَرُّ الْبَرِيَّةِ

Indeed, those who disbelieved among the People of the Book and the polytheists will be in the Fire of Hell, abiding eternally. They are the worst of creatures.

Ibn Kathīr

Those who opposed Allah's revealed books and His prophets will be in Jahannam on the Day of Resurrection, remaining there forever, never leaving. They are the worst of all that Allah has created.

as-Sa'dī

They are the worst of creation because they knew the truth and abandoned it — knowledge without submission makes their case the gravest.

al-Jalālayn

Khālidīn: abiding there — decreed for them by Allah. Sharr al-bariyyah: the worst of creation.

Āyah 7 • The best of creation



إِنَّ الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمْ خَيْرُ الْبَرِيَّةِ

Indeed, those who believed and did righteous deeds — they are the best of creatures.

Ibn Kathīr

Those who believe with their hearts and act righteously with their limbs are the best of creation. Abū Hurayrah and a group of scholars used this āyah to argue that believers are superior to the angels.

as-Sa‘dī

They are the best of creation because they combined beneficial knowledge and righteous action — the exact opposite of those in āyah 6.

al-Jalālayn

Khayr al-bariyyah: the best of creation.

Āyah 8 · Their reward — and the key: khashyah



جَزَاؤُهُمْ عِنْدَ رَبِّهِمْ جَنَّاتٌ عَدْنٌ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ خَالِدِينَ فِيهَا أَبَدًا رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمْ وَرَضُوا عَنْهُ ذَلِكَ لِمَنْ خَشِيَ رَبَّهُ

Their reward with their Lord is gardens of perpetual residence beneath which rivers flow, abiding therein forever. Allah is pleased with them, and they with Him. That is for whoever fears his Lord.

Ibn Kathīr

Eternal gardens without end. Allah's pleasure is higher than all the bliss given them. This is for whoever fears Allah as He should be feared and worships Him as though he sees Him.

as-Sa'dī

Khashyah is fear joined with knowledge of Allah — “only those with knowledge truly fear Allah” (Fāṭir 35:28). So it drives a person to obey and to keep away from what Allah forbids.

al-Jalālayn

‘Adn: residence. Li-man khashiya rabbah: whoever fears His punishment and so refrains from disobeying Him.

Key words of the sūrah

munfakkīn

desisting, separating from a state

مُنْفَكِّينَ

al-bayyinah

the clear proof — the Messenger ﷺ

الْبَيِّنَةُ

ṣuḥuf muṭahharah

pages purified of falsehood

صُحُفًا مُطَهَّرَةً

qayyimah

upright, straight, just

قِيَمَةً

ḥunafā'

inclining away from shirk to tawḥīd

حُنَفَاءَ

al-bariyyah

creation — from bara'a, to create

الْبَرِيَّةِ

ʿadn

permanent residence

عَدْنٍ

khashiya

feared, with knowledge and awe

خَشْيٍ

From the wider tafsīr tradition

aṭ-Ṭabarī

Records two readings of munfakkīn: they would not cease from disbelief until the proof came; or the People of the Book would not part from what they knew of the Prophet's description in their books — until he came, and then they split over him.

al-Qurṭubī

Lists the sūrah's names (Lam Yakun, al-Bayyinah, al-Qayyimah, al-Bariyyah, al-Munfakkīn). Draws from āyah 5 that intention (niyyah) is required in worship, since ikhlāṣ is commanded.

al-Baghawī

Explains al-bayyinah as the Messenger ﷺ and the Qur'ān he brought; qayyimah as just and straight, with no crookedness. Notes that sincerity and ḥanīfiyyah are the shared core of all prophets' messages.

Two groups, one proof

شَرُّ الْبَرِيَّةِ

Response to proof Rejected it knowingly

Deeds Divided, followed desire

Inner state Envy and pride

Abode Jahannam, forever

Ultimate end Eternal loss

خَيْرُ الْبَرِيَّةِ

Response to proof Believed in it

Deeds Righteous deeds, ṣalāh, zakāh

Inner state Ikhlāṣ and khashyah

Abode Jannāt ‘Adn, forever

Ultimate end Mutual riḍā with their Lord

Lessons to carry



Knowledge demands response

Once the proof reaches you, no excuse remains (āyāt 1, 4).



Division comes from desire

The Book unites; envy and transgression divide (āyah 4).



Ikhlāṣ is the core

Every prophet's message: sincere worship, inclining away from shirk (āyah 5).



Īmān includes deeds

Ṣalāh and zakāh are named within the upright religion (āyah 5).



Belief + action = best

Neither alone; together they raise a person above creation (āyah 7).



Khashyah opens Jannah

Fear rooted in knowing Allah is the gate to His pleasure (āyah 8).

رَضِيَ اللَّهُ عَنْهُمْ وَرَضُوا عَنْهُ ج ذَلِكَ لِمَنْ خَشِيَ رَبَّهُ

“Allah is pleased with them, and they with Him. That is for whoever fears his Lord.” — 98:8



References

Ibn Kathīr, Tafsīr al-Qur’ān al-‘Aẓīm • as-Sa’dī, Taysīr al-Karīm ar-Raḥmān • al-Maḥallī & as-Suyūṭī, Tafsīr al-Jalālayn • aṭ-Ṭabarī, Jāmi‘ al-Bayān • al-Qurṭubī, al-Jāmi‘ li-Aḥkām al-Qur’ān • al-Baghawī, Ma‘ālim at-Tanzīl • Ṣaḥīḥ al-Bukhārī 4959; Ṣaḥīḥ Muslim 799